PADHAKU
Democratic Politics · Class 10 Social Science



CHAPTER 3

Gender, Religion and Caste

NCERT Exercise Solutions

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✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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💬 Discuss · Public/private division

? **Cartoon: “Why are we discussing things like household work in this textbook on Political Science? Is this politics?”**

“Why not? If politics is about power, then surely male dominance in the household should be considered political.” What do you think?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Yes, household work and male dominance at home are political issues.

- Politics is about **power**: who decides, who gets resources and whose work is valued.
- The **sexual division of labour** keeps women busy with unpaid housework, so their role in public life and politics stays small.
- Women's movements raised these 'private' issues in politics and won better legal status, education and jobs for women.

So the private division of work at home has public, political effects and should be discussed.

? **Discuss all these perceptions of an ideal woman that prevail in our society (ideal viewer, ideal beauty, ideal housewife, ideal bride, ideal employee). Do you agree with any**

of these? If not, what is your image of an ideal woman?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Model answer: I do not agree with these images.

- Each one sees a woman only through what others want from her: TV makers want a viewer, the fashion industry a beauty, society a housewife doing ten jobs, in-laws a bride with dowry, employers a decorative employee.
- These are **stereotypes**; they judge women by looks, dowry or service, not by ability.
- My ideal woman is a person with equal rights and opportunities: educated, free to choose her work and life, respected at home and outside, and taking part in decisions, including politics.
- Men should share housework so that women can do this.

🧪 Activity · Time use survey

? **Daily time use (hours:minutes) — Men / Women:**

Income generating work 6:00 / 2:40; Household work 0:30 / 5:00; Talking, gossip 1:25 / 1:20; No work/leisure 3:40 / 3:50; Sleep, self-care, reading 12:25 / 11:10.

Conduct a similar time use survey in your household for one week and calculate the daily average for each member. Do women work more in your family as well?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Sample plan and result:

- Make a table for each adult member with columns: income work, household work (cooking, cleaning, fetching water, care of children/elders), reading/recreation, talking, self-care/rest/sleep.
- Note hours every day for 7 days, add them up and divide by 7 to get the daily average.

Activity	Father	Mother
Income generating work	8:00	1:00
Household work	0:45	6:30
Total work	8:45	7:30 + extra care tasks

- In most families, like in the survey (women 7:40 h, men 6:30 h of total work), women work more, but most of their work is unpaid and invisible.

(Fill in your own family's figures.)

🤔 Think · Women's work

? **"Mummy always says to outsiders: 'I don't work. I am a housewife.' But I see her working**

non-stop all the time. If what she does is not work, what else is work?"

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Housework is real work, even though it is not paid.

- Cooking, cleaning, washing, fetching water and looking after children and elders take many hours every day.
- An average Indian woman works about one hour more than a man every day, but because this work is unpaid, it is not valued or recognised.
- So we should count and respect housework as work.

⭐ Map · Child sex ratio, 2011

1 **Can you identify your State on this map? What is the child sex ratio in it? How is it different from others with a different colour?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Sample (Delhi): Delhi is in the lightest colour, 'Below 875' girls per 1,000 boys (aged 0–6).

- It is among the worst; States in pink like Kerala, Chhattisgarh and West Bengal have 951 and above.

(Find your own State and its colour in the legend.)

2 **Identify the States which have child sex ratio below 900.**

✔ ANSWER

From the map (Census 2011):

- **Below 875:** Jammu & Kashmir, Punjab, Haryana, Delhi.
- **876–900:** Rajasthan, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Uttarakhand.

3 **Compare this map with the poster on the next page ("50 million women missing in South Asia"). How do the two of them tell us about the same issue?**

✔ ANSWER

Both show discrimination against girls and women.

- The map shows, State by State, that there are fewer girls than boys because of sex-selective abortion and neglect of the girl child.
- The poster shows the result for the whole of South Asia: 50 million women are 'missing' due to violence and discrimination.
- The map gives the data; the poster is a campaign asking people to end this violence.

💬 Discuss · Women's political representation

? Could you think of some reasons why women's representation is so low in India? Do you think Americas and Europe have achieved a satisfactory level of women's representation?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Reasons for low representation in India:

- Male-dominated, patriarchal society; politics is seen as a man's field.
- Burden of housework and child care leaves women little time.
- Lower literacy and fewer resources/money for contesting elections.
- Parties give fewer tickets to women; fear of violence and harassment.

Americas (29.5%) and Europe (26.4%) are above the world average (24%) but still far below half, so their level is not satisfactory. Only the Nordic countries (42.3%) come close to equality.

? Do you think that women could have made the gains we noted above if their unequal treatment was not raised in the political domain?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

No. Women gained because their issues became political.

- Agitations got women the right to vote and better legal status.
- Political demands led to one-third reservation in panchayats and municipalities (now over 10 lakh women representatives) and the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023.
- Laws like the Equal Remuneration Act, 1976 also came through politics.

So raising gender issues in politics helped this disadvantaged group.

? **If casteism and communalism are bad, what makes feminism a good thing? Why don't we oppose all those who divide the society on any lines – caste, religion or gender?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Feminism is different from casteism and communalism.

- Feminism asks for **equal rights and opportunities** for women and men; it does not claim one group is superior or try to dominate others.
- Communalism and casteism treat religion or caste as the only basis of community and seek domination or exclusion.
- Feminism expresses a real disadvantage in order to remove inequality; this is healthy in a democracy.

So we should oppose divisions that create domination, not demands that seek equality.

💬 Discuss · Religion, communalism and politics

? "I am not religious. Why should I bother about communalism and secularism?"

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Even a non-religious person should care.

- Communalism threatens the **very idea of India**, not only some people; it can lead to prejudice, riots and violence that affect everyone.
- Secularism protects every citizen's freedom to follow any religion **or none**.
- So everyone has a stake in countering communal prejudice and supporting a secular state.

? "I often crack jokes about people from one religion. Does that make me communal?"

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Yes, it can be a form of communalism.

- The most common expression of communalism is in **everyday beliefs**: religious prejudices, stereotypes and belief that one's own religion is superior.
- Such jokes spread stereotypes, and this is so common that we often do not notice it.

- We should avoid such jokes and respect all religions.

💬 Discuss · Caste and politics

? **Cartoon: "I don't care what my caste is. Why are we discussing all this in the textbook? Are we not promoting casteism by talking about caste?"**

"Now you don't like it! Didn't you tell me that wherever there is domination, we should discuss it in Political Science? Will caste disappear if we keep mum about it?"

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Discussing caste does not promote casteism.

- Caste inequality still exists: marriage within caste, untouchability not fully ended, and caste is linked to economic status (more poverty among SCs and STs).
- Wherever there is domination and inequality, Political Science must study it.
- Keeping silent will not end caste; understanding it helps us remove injustice.

? **Do you think that political leaders are right to treat people belonging to a caste as 'vote banks'?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

No, it is not right.

- No party wins all the votes of a caste; rich and poor, men and women of the same caste often vote differently.
- Voters also judge the government's performance, leaders' popularity and party loyalty.
- Treating a caste as a vote bank diverts attention from real issues like poverty, development and corruption, and can cause tension.

Leaders should appeal to people as citizens, not only as caste members.

📝 Exercises

1 **Mention different aspects of life in which women are discriminated or disadvantaged in India.**

✔ ANSWER

Women in India face discrimination in many areas:

1. **Education:** literacy rate among women is only 54% compared with 76% among men; fewer girls go for higher studies because parents spend more on sons.

2. **Jobs:** very few women are in highly paid and valued jobs.

3. **Wages:** despite the Equal Remuneration Act, 1976, women are paid less than men for the same work.

4. **Unpaid work:** a woman works about one hour more than a man daily, but much of her work is unpaid and not valued.

5. **Sex ratio:** sex-selective abortion has brought the child sex ratio down to 919 (below 850 or even 800 in some States).

6. **Safety:** harassment, exploitation and violence, including domestic violence; urban areas are unsafe.

7. **Politics:** low share in Lok Sabha (14.36% in 2019) and state assemblies (less than 5%).

Thus India is still a male-dominated, patriarchal society.

2 **State different forms of communal politics with one example each.**

✔ ANSWER

Communalism takes various forms in politics:

1. **Everyday beliefs:** religious prejudices, stereotypes and belief that one's religion is superior. *Example:* jokes and stereotypes about people of another religion.

2. **Quest for political dominance:** for the majority it becomes majoritarian dominance; for a minority, a desire for a separate political unit. *Example:* demand for a separate state for one religious community.

3. **Political mobilisation on religious lines:** use of sacred symbols, religious leaders, emotional appeal and fear. *Example:* special appeals to voters of one religion during elections.

4. **Communal violence, riots and massacre:** its ugliest form. *Example:* the riots at the time of the Partition of India and Pakistan.

3 **State how caste inequalities are still continuing in India.**

✔ ANSWER

Caste has not disappeared from India:

1. Most people still **marry within their own caste or tribe**.

2. **Untouchability** has not ended completely, despite constitutional prohibition.

3. Groups that had education earlier have done well in modern education; others lagged behind, so 'upper castes' are over-represented in the urban middle class.

4. Caste is still linked to **economic status**: upper castes are best off, Dalits and Adivasis worst off, backward classes in between.

5. The share of people in **extreme poverty** is much higher among the lowest castes (e.g. 45.8% of rural STs, 35.9% of rural SCs against 11.7% of Hindu upper castes, 1999–2000).

6. Upper castes are heavily over-represented among the rich.

Thus the effects of centuries of advantages and disadvantages are still felt.

4 **State two reasons to say that caste alone cannot determine election results in India.**

✔ ANSWER

1. **No constituency has a clear majority of one caste.** So every candidate and party must win the confidence of more than one caste and community.

2. **No party wins all the votes of a caste.** A 'vote bank' only means a large share of that caste votes for the party; rich and poor, men and women of the same caste often vote differently.

Other reasons: many parties may field candidates of the same caste; the ruling party and sitting MPs/MLAs often lose; voters judge the government's performance and leaders' popularity.

5 **What is the status of women's representation in India's legislative bodies?**

✔ ANSWER

Women's representation in India is very low:

1. Elected women in **Lok Sabha** touched **14.36%** for the first time only in 2019.

2. Their share in **state assemblies** is **less than 5%**.

3. India is among the **bottom group of nations** in the world, behind many developing countries of Africa and Latin America.

4. Cabinets are largely all-male, even when a woman is Chief Minister or Prime Minister.

5. In **local bodies** (panchayats and municipalities) one-third of seats are reserved for women; there are now more than **10 lakh** elected women representatives.

6. The **Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam (Women's Reservation Act), 2023** will give 33% reservation for women in Lok Sabha, State Legislative Assemblies and the Delhi Assembly.

6 **Mention any two constitutional provisions that make India a secular state.**

✔ ANSWER

1. There is **no official religion** for the Indian state (unlike Buddhism in Sri Lanka, Islam in Pakistan, Christianity in England).

2. The Constitution gives all individuals and communities **freedom to profess, practise and propagate any religion, or not to follow any**.

Also: it **prohibits discrimination on grounds of religion**, and it allows the state to intervene in religion to ensure equality within religious communities (e.g. it bans untouchability).

7 When we speak of gender divisions, we usually refer to:

(a) Biological difference between men and women

(b) Unequal roles assigned by the society to men and women

(c) Unequal child sex ratio

(d) Absence of voting rights for women in democracies

✔ ANSWER

(b) Unequal roles assigned by the society to men and women.

Gender division is based not on biology but on social expectations and stereotypes.

8 In India seats are reserved for women in

(a) Lok Sabha

(b) State legislative assemblies

(c) Cabinets

(d) Panchayati Raj bodies

✔ ANSWER

(d) Panchayati Raj bodies.

One-third of seats in panchayats and municipalities are reserved for women. (The Women's Reservation Act, 2023 will also give 33% reservation in Lok Sabha and State Assemblies once it comes into force.)

9 Communal politics is based on the belief that:

A. One religion is superior to that of others.

B. People belonging to different religions can live together happily as equal citizens.

C. Followers of a particular religion constitute one community.

D. State power cannot be used to establish the domination of one religious group over others.

Which of the statements are correct?

(a) A, B, C, and D (b) A, B, and D (c) A and C (d) B and D

✔ ANSWER

(c) A and C.

B and D are secular ideas; communalism believes one religion is superior and its followers form one community.

10 Which among the following statements about India's Constitution is wrong? It

(a) prohibits discrimination on grounds of religion.

(b) gives official status to one religion.

(c) provides to all individuals freedom to profess any religion.

(d) ensures equality of citizens within religious communities.

✔ ANSWER

(b) gives official status to one religion.
India has no official religion; it is a secular state.

11 **Social divisions based on _____ are peculiar to India.**

✔ ANSWER
Caste.
Unlike gender and religion, caste division is special to India.

12 **Match List I with List II:**
1. A person who believes in equal rights and opportunities for women and men — A. Communalist
2. A person who says that religion is the principal basis of community — B. Feminist
3. A person who thinks that caste is the principal basis of community — C. Secularist
4. A person who does not discriminate others on the basis of religious beliefs — D. Castiest
Codes (1 2 3 4): (a) B C A D (b) B A D C (c) D C A B (d) C A B D

✔ ANSWER
(b) B A D C.
1 – Feminist, 2 – Communalist, 3 – Castiest, 4 – Secularist.

🎉 **Chapter 3 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**